

The “identify” step is for the pilot to initially identify the failed engine. Confirmation on the engine gauges may or may not be possible, depending upon the failure mode. Identification should be primarily through the control inputs required to maintain straight flight, not the engine gauges. The “verify” step directs the pilot to retard the throttle of the engine thought to have failed. No change in performance when the suspected throttle is retarded is verification that the correct engine has been identified as failed. The corresponding propeller control should be brought fully aft to feather the engine.

Engine Failure After Takeoff	
Airspeed	Maintain V_{YSE}
Mixtures	RICH
Propellers	HIGH RPM
Throttles.....	FULL POWER
Flaps	UP
Landing gear	UP
Identify	Determine failed engine
Verify	Close throttle of failed engine
Propeller	FEATHER
Trim tabs	ADJUST
Failed engine.....	SECURE
As soon as practical	LAND
Bold-faced items require immediate action and are to be accomplished from memory.	

Figure 13-21. Typical “engine failure after takeoff” emergency checklist.

Climb

As soon as directional control is established and the airplane configured for climb, the bank angle should be reduced to that producing best climb performance. Without specific guidance for zero sideslip, a bank of 2° and one-third to one-half ball deflection on the slip/skid indicator toward the operative engine is suggested. V_{YSE} is maintained with pitch control. As turning flight reduces climb performance, climb should be made straight ahead or with shallow turns to avoid obstacles to an altitude of at least 400 feet AGL before attempting a return to the airport.

Checklist

Having accomplished the memory items from the engine failure after takeoff checklist, the printed copy should be reviewed as time permits. The securing failed engine checklist should then be accomplished. [Figure 13-22] Unless the pilot suspects an engine fire, the remaining items should be accomplished deliberately and without undue haste. Airplane control should never be sacrificed to execute the remaining checklists. The priority items have already been accomplished from memory.

Securing Failed Engine

Mixture	IDLE CUT OFF
Magnetos	OFF
Alternator	OFF
Cowl flap	CLOSE
Boost pump	OFF
Fuel selector	OFF
Prop sync	OFF
Electrical load	Reduce
Crossfeed	Consider

Figure 13-22. Typical “securing failed engine” emergency checklist.

Other than closing the cowl flap of the failed engine, none of these items, if left undone, adversely affect airplane climb performance. There is a distinct possibility of actuating an incorrect switch or control if the procedure is rushed. The pilot should concentrate on flying the airplane and extracting maximum performance. If an ATC facility is available, an emergency should be declared.

The memory items in the engine failure after takeoff checklist may be redundant with the airplane’s existing configuration. For example, in the third takeoff scenario, the gear and flaps were assumed to already be retracted, yet the memory items included gear and flaps. This is not an oversight. The purpose of the memory items is to either initiate the appropriate action or to confirm that a condition exists. Action on each item may not be required in all cases. The memory items also apply to more than one circumstance. In an engine failure from a go-around, for example, the landing gear and flaps would likely be extended when the failure occurred.

The three preceding takeoff scenarios all include the landing gear as a key element in the decision to land or continue. With the landing gear selector in the DOWN position, for example, continued takeoff and climb is not recommended. This situation, however, is not justification to retract the landing gear the moment the airplane lifts off the surface on takeoff as a normal procedure. The landing gear should remain selected down as long as there is usable runway or overrun available to land on. The use of wing flaps for takeoff virtually eliminates the likelihood of a single-engine climb until the flaps are retracted.

There are two time-tested memory aids the pilot may find useful in dealing with engine-out scenarios. The first, “dead foot—dead engine” is used to assist in identifying the failed engine. Depending on the failure mode, the pilot will not be able to consistently identify the failed engine in a timely manner from the engine gauges. In maintaining directional control, however, rudder pressure is exerted on the side (left or right) of the airplane with the operating engine. Thus, the “dead foot” is on the same side as the “dead engine.” Variations on this saying include “idle foot—idle engine” and “working foot—working engine.”

The second memory aid has to do with climb performance. The phrase “raise the dead” is a reminder that the best climb performance is obtained with a very shallow bank, about 2° toward the operating engine. Therefore, the inoperative, or “dead” engine should be “raised” with a very slight bank.

Not all engine failures result in complete power loss. If there is a performance loss when the throttle of the affected engine is retarded, some power is still available. In this case, the pilot may consider allowing the engine to run until the airplane reaches a safe altitude and airspeed for single-engine flight. While shutdown of a malfunctioning engine may prevent additional damage to the engine in certain circumstances, shutting down an engine that can still produce partial power may increase risk for an accident.

Engine Failure During Flight

Engine failures well above the ground are handled differently than those occurring at lower speeds and altitudes. Cruise airspeed allows better airplane control and altitude, which may permit time for a possible diagnosis and remedy of the failure. Maintaining airplane control, however, is still paramount. Airplanes have been lost at altitude due to apparent fixation on the engine problem to the detriment of flying the airplane.

Not all engine failures or malfunctions are catastrophic in nature (catastrophic meaning a major mechanical failure that damages the engine and precludes further engine operation). Many cases of power loss are related to fuel starvation, where restoration of power may be made with the selection of another tank. An orderly inventory of gauges and switches may reveal the problem. Carburetor heat or alternate air can be selected. The affected engine may run smoothly on just one magneto or at a lower power setting. Altering the mixture may help. If fuel vapor formation is suspected, fuel boost pump operation may be used to eliminate flow and pressure fluctuations.

Although it is a natural desire among pilots to save an ailing engine with a precautionary shutdown, the engine should be left running if there is any doubt as to needing it for further safe flight. Catastrophic failure accompanied by heavy vibration, smoke, blistering paint, or large trails of oil, on the other hand, indicate a critical situation. The affected engine should be feathered and the securing failed engine checklist completed. The pilot should divert to the nearest suitable airport and declare an emergency with ATC for priority handling.

Fuel crossfeed is a method of getting fuel from a tank on one side of the airplane to an operating engine on the other. Crossfeed is used for extended single-engine operation. If a suitable airport is close at hand, there is no need to consider crossfeed. If prolonged flight on a single-engine is inevitable due to airport non-availability, then crossfeed allows use of fuel that would otherwise be unavailable to the operating engine. It also permits the pilot to balance the fuel consumption to avoid an out-of-balance wing heaviness.

The AFM/POH procedures for crossfeed vary widely. Thorough fuel system knowledge is essential if crossfeed is to be conducted. Fuel selector positions and fuel boost pump usage for crossfeed differ greatly among multiengine airplanes. Prior to landing, crossfeed should be terminated and the operating engine returned to its main tank fuel supply.

If the airplane is above its single-engine absolute ceiling at the time of engine failure, it slowly loses altitude. The pilot should maintain V_{YSE} to minimize the rate of altitude loss. This “drift down” rate is greatest immediately following the failure and decreases as the single-engine ceiling is approached. Due to performance variations caused by engine and propeller wear, turbulence, and pilot technique, the airplane may not maintain altitude even at its published single-engine ceiling. Any further rate of sink, however, would likely be modest.

An engine failure in a descent or other low power setting can be deceiving. The dramatic yaw and performance loss is absent. At very low power settings, the pilot may not even be aware of a failure. If a failure is suspected, the pilot should advance both engine mixtures, propellers, and throttles significantly, to the takeoff settings if necessary, to correctly identify the failed engine. The power on the operative engine can always be reduced later.

Engine Inoperative Approach and Landing

The approach and landing with OEI is essentially the same as a two-engine approach and landing. The traffic pattern should be flown at similar altitudes, airspeeds, and key positions as a two-engine approach. The differences are the reduced power available and the fact that the remaining thrust is asymmetrical. A higher-than-normal power setting is necessary on the operative engine.

With adequate airspeed and performance, the landing gear can still be extended on the downwind leg. In which case it should be confirmed DOWN no later than abeam the intended point of landing. Performance permitting, initial extension of wing flaps (typically 10°) and a descent from pattern altitude can also be initiated on the downwind leg. The airspeed should be no slower than V_{YSE} . The direction of the traffic pattern, and therefore the turns, is of no consequence as far as airplane controllability and performance are concerned. It is perfectly acceptable to make turns toward the failed engine.

On the base leg, if performance is adequate, the flaps may be extended to an intermediate setting (typically 25°). If the performance is inadequate, as measured by decay in airspeed or high sink rate, delay further flap extension until closer to the runway. V_{YSE} is still the minimum airspeed to maintain.

On final approach, a normal 3° glidepath to a landing is desirable. Visual approach slope indicator (VASI) or other vertical path lighting aids should be utilized if available. Slightly steeper approaches may be acceptable. However, a long, flat, low approach should be avoided. Large, sudden power applications or reductions should also be avoided. Maintain V_{YSE} until the landing is assured, then slow to $1.3 V_{SO}$ or the AFM/POH recommended speed. The final flap setting may be delayed until the landing is assured or the airplane may be landed with partial flaps.

The airplane should remain in trim throughout. The pilot should be prepared, however, for a rudder trim change as the power of the operating engine is reduced to idle in the round out just prior to touchdown. With drag from only one windmilling propeller, the airplane tends to float more than on a two-engine approach. Precise airspeed control therefore is essential, especially when landing on a short, wet, and/or slippery surface.

Some pilots favor resetting the rudder trim to neutral on final and compensating for yaw by holding rudder pressure for the remainder of the approach. This eliminates the rudder trim change close to the ground as the throttle is closed during the round out for landing. This technique eliminates the need for groping for the rudder trim and manipulating it to neutral during final approach, which many pilots find to be highly distracting. AFM/POH recommendations or personal preference should be used.

A single-engine go-around on final approach may not be possible. As a practical matter in single-engine approaches, once the airplane is on final approach with landing gear and flaps extended, it is committed to land on the intended runway, on another runway, a taxiway, or grassy infield. Most light-twins do not have the performance to climb on one engine with landing gear and flaps extended. Considerable altitude is lost while maintaining V_{YSE} and retracting landing gear and flaps. Losses of 500 feet or more are not unusual. If the landing gear has been lowered with an alternate means of extension, retraction may not be possible, virtually negating any climb capability.

Multiengine Training Considerations

Flight training in a multiengine airplane can be safely accomplished if both the instructor and the learner consider the following factors.

- The participants should conduct a preflight briefing of the objectives, maneuvers, expected learner actions, and completion standards before the flight begins.
- A clear understanding exists as to how simulated emergencies will be introduced, and what action the learner is expected to take.

The introduction, practice, and testing of emergency procedures has always been a sensitive subject. Surprising a multiengine learner with an emergency without a thorough briefing beforehand creates a hazardous condition. Simulated engine failures, for example, can very quickly become actual emergencies or lead to loss of the airplane when approached carelessly. Stall-spin accidents in training for emergencies rival the number of stall-spin accidents from actual emergencies. The training risk normally gets mitigated by a briefing. Pulling circuit breakers is not recommended for training purposes and can lead to a subsequent gear up landing.

Many normal, abnormal, and emergency procedures can be introduced and practiced in the airplane as it sits on the ground without the engines running. In this respect, the airplane is used as a procedures trainer. The value of this training may be substantial. The engines do not have to be operating for real learning to occur. Upon completion of a training session, care should be taken to restore items to their proper positions.

Pilots who do not use a checklist effectively will be at a significant disadvantage in multiengine airplanes. Use of the checklist is essential to safe operation of airplanes, and it is risky to conduct a flight without one. The manufacturer's checklist or an aftermarket checklist that conforms to the manufacturer's procedures for the specific make, model, and model year may be used. If there is a procedural discrepancy between the checklist and the AFM/POH, then the AFM/POH always takes precedence.

Certain immediate action items (such as a response to an engine failure in a critical phase of flight) are best committed to memory. After they are accomplished, and as work load permits, the pilot can compare the action taken with a checklist.

Simulated engine failures during the takeoff ground roll may be accomplished with the mixture control. The simulated failure should be introduced at a speed no greater than 50 percent of V_{MC} . If a learner does not react promptly by retarding both throttles, the instructor can always pull the other mixture.

The FAA recommends that all in-flight simulated engine failures below 3,000 feet AGL, be introduced with a smooth reduction of the throttle. Thus, the engine is kept running and is available for instant use, if necessary. Smooth throttle reduction avoids abusing the engine and possibly causing damage. Simulation of inflight engine failures below V_{SSE} introduces a very high and unnecessary training risk.

If the engines are equipped with dynamic crankshaft counterweights, it is essential to make throttle reductions for simulated failures smoothly. Other areas leading to dynamic counterweight damage include high rpm and low manifold pressure combinations, overboosting, and propeller feathering. Severe damage or repetitive abuse to counterweights will eventually lead to engine failure. Dynamic counterweights are found on larger, more complex engines—instructors may check with maintenance personnel or the engine manufacturer to determine if their airplane engines are so equipped.

When an instructor simulates an engine failure, the learner should respond with the appropriate memory items and retard the appropriate propeller control toward the FEATHER position. Assuming zero thrust will be set, the instructor promptly moves the propeller control forward and sets the appropriate manifold pressure and rpm. It is vital that the learner be kept informed of the instructor's intentions. At this point the instructor may say words to the effect, "I have the right engine; you have the left. I have set zero thrust and the right engine is simulated feathered." Any ambiguity as to who is operating what systems or controls increases the likelihood of an unintended outcome.

Following a simulated engine failure, the instructor cares for the "failed" engine just as the learner cares for the operative engine. If zero thrust is set to simulate a feathered propeller, the cowl flap is normally closed and the mixture leaned. An occasional clearing of the engine is also desirable. If possible, avoid high power applications immediately following a prolonged cool-down at a zero-thrust power setting. A competent flight instructor teaches the multiengine learner about the critical importance of feathering the propeller in a timely manner should an actual engine failure situation ever be encountered. A windmilling propeller, in many cases, has given the improperly trained multiengine pilot the mistaken perception that the engine is still developing useful thrust, resulting in a psychological reluctance to feather, as feathering results in cessation of propeller rotation. The flight instructor should spend ample time demonstrating the difference in the performance capabilities of the airplane with a simulated feathered propeller (zero thrust) as opposed to a windmilling propeller.

Actual and safe propeller feathering for training is performed at altitudes and positions where safe landings on established airports may be readily accomplished if the propeller will not unfeather. Plan unfeathering and restart to be completed no lower than 3,000 feet AGL. At certain elevations and with many popular multiengine training airplanes, this may be above the single-engine service ceiling, and level flight will not be possible.

Repeated feathering and unfeathering is hard on the engine and airframe, and is done as necessary to ensure adequate training. The FAA's Airman Certification Standards for a multiengine class rating contains a task for feathering and unfeathering of one propeller during flight in airplanes in which it is safe to do so.

While much of this chapter has been devoted to the unique flight characteristics of a multiengine airplane with one engine inoperative, the modern well-maintained reciprocating engine is remarkably reliable. When training in an airplane, initiation of a simulated engine inoperative emergency at low altitude normally occurs at a minimum of 400 feet AGL to mitigate the risk involved and only after the learner has successfully mastered engine inoperative procedures at higher altitudes. Initiating a simulated low altitude engine inoperative emergency in the airplane at extremely low altitude, immediately after liftoff, or below V_{SSE} creates a situation where there are non-existent safety margins.

For training in maneuvers that would be hazardous in flight, or for initial and recurrent qualification in an advanced multiengine airplane, consider a simulator training center or manufacturer's training course. Comprehensive training manuals and classroom instruction are available along with system training aids, audio/visuals, and flight training devices and simulators. Training under a wide variety of environmental and aircraft conditions is available through simulation. Emergency procedures that would be either dangerous or impossible to accomplish in an airplane can be done safely and effectively in a flight training device or simulator. The flight training device or simulator need not necessarily duplicate the specific make and model of airplane to be useful. Highly effective instruction can be obtained in training devices for other makes and models as well as generic training devices.

The majority of multiengine training is conducted in four-to-six place airplanes at weights significantly less than maximum. Single-engine performance, particularly, at low density altitudes, may be deceptively good. To experience the performance expected at higher weights, altitudes and temperatures, the instructor may occasionally artificially limit the amount of manifold pressure available on the operative engine. Airport operations above the single-engine ceiling can also be simulated in this matter. Avoid loading the airplane with passengers to practice emergencies at maximum takeoff weight since this practice creates an unnecessary training hazard.

The use of the touch-and-go landing and takeoff in multiengine flight training has always been somewhat controversial. The value of the learning experience may be offset by the hazards of reconfiguring the airplane for takeoff in extremely limited time as well as the loss of the follow-through ordinarily experienced in a full stop landing. Touch-and-goes are not recommended during initial aircraft familiarization in multiengine airplanes.

If touch-and-goes are to be performed at all, the learner and instructor responsibilities should be carefully briefed prior to each flight. Following touchdown, the learner will ordinarily maintain directional control while keeping the left hand on the yoke and the right hand on the throttles. The instructor resets the flaps and trim and announces when the airplane has been reconfigured. The multiengine airplane uses considerably more runway to perform a touch-and-go than a single-engine airplane. A full stop-taxi back landing is preferable during initial familiarization. Solo touch-and-goes in twins are strongly discouraged.

Chapter Summary

Small multiengine airplanes handle much like single-engine airplanes as long as both engines are functioning normally. A competent multiengine pilot, however, acquires the additional knowledge, risk mitigation strategies, and practical skills required to fly a multiengine airplane in case a loss of thrust from one engine actually occurs. In that case, the pilot will be able to take appropriate action leading to a safe outcome. Much of this chapter discussed loss of directional control. How to obtain the best performance with an inoperative engine was also described in detail. These two considerations correspond to the red radial line (V_{MC}) and the blue radial line (V_{YSE}) on the airspeed indicator. The actions a pilot takes when dealing with stalls, V_{MC} , or best performance vary greatly. Understanding these concepts, knowing how to mitigate the risks, and possessing the skills to handle an engine failure in a variety of situations, allows a pilot to enjoy the increased performance and safety provided when flying a multiengine airplane.

Airplane Flying Handbook (FAA-H-8083-3C)

Chapter 14: Transition to Tailwheel Airplanes

Introduction

Due to their design and structure, tailwheel airplanes (tailwheels) exhibit operational and handling characteristics different from those of tricycle-gear airplanes (nose-wheels). [Figure 14-1] A few aircraft, primarily antique and experimental, may have a tailskid instead of a tailwheel. The same principles discussed in this chapter usually apply to tailskid. In general, tailwheels are less forgiving of pilot error while in contact with the ground than are nose-wheels. This chapter focuses on the operational differences that occur during ground operations, takeoffs, and landings.

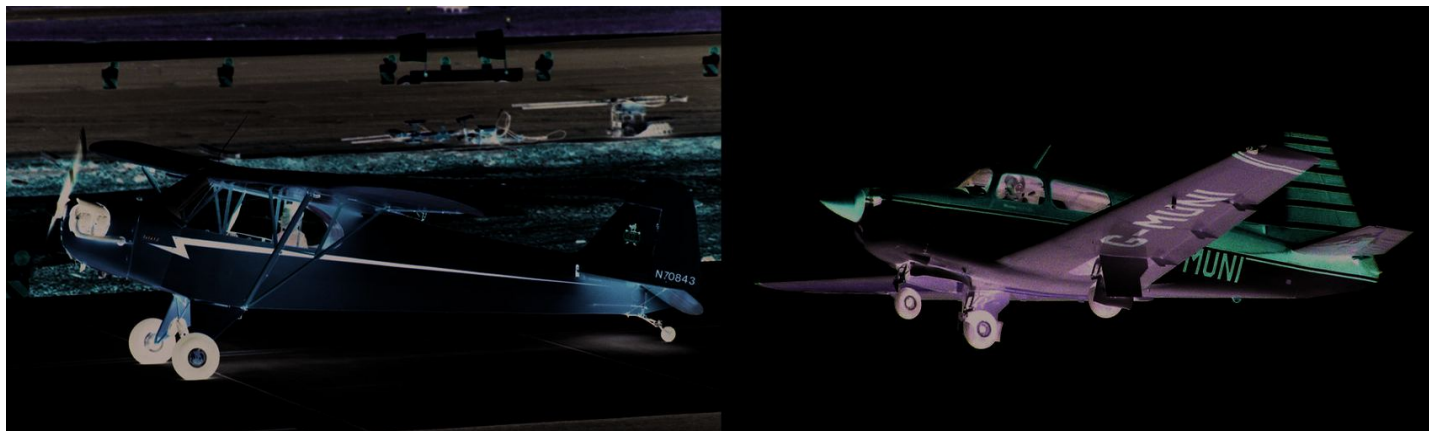


Figure 14-1. The Piper Super Cub on the left is a popular tailwheel airplane. The airplane on the right is a Mooney M20, which is a nose-wheel (tricycle gear) airplane.

Although still termed “conventional-gear airplanes,” tailwheel designs are most likely to be encountered today by pilots who have first learned in nose-wheels. Therefore, tailwheel operations are approached as they appear to a pilot making a transition from nose-wheel designs.

Landing Gear

The main landing gear forms the principal support of the airplane on the ground. The tailwheel also supports the airplane, but steering and directional control are its primary functions. With the tailwheel-type airplane, the two main landing gear struts are attached to the airplane slightly ahead of the airplane’s center of gravity (CG), so that the plane naturally rests in a nose-high attitude on the triangle created by the main gear and the tailwheel. This arrangement is responsible for the three major handling differences between nose-wheel and tailwheel airplanes. They center on directional instability, angle of attack (AOA), and crosswind weathervaning tendencies.

Proper usage of the rudder pedals is crucial for directional control while taxiing. Steering with the pedals may be accomplished through the forces of airflow or propeller slipstream acting on the rudder surface or through a direct mechanical linkage or a mechanical linkage acting through springs to turn the tailwheel. Initially, the pilot should taxi with the heels of the feet resting on the floor and the balls of the feet on the bottom of the rudder pedals. The feet should be slid up onto the brake pedals only when it is necessary to depress the brakes. This permits the simultaneous application of rudder and brake whenever needed. Some models of tailwheel airplanes are equipped with heel brakes rather than toe brakes. As in nose-wheel airplanes, brakes are used to slow and stop the aircraft and to increase turning authority when tailwheel steering inputs prove insufficient. Whenever used, brakes should be applied smoothly and evenly.

Instability

Because of the relative placement of the main gear and the CG, tailwheel aircraft are inherently unstable on the ground. As taxi turns are started, the aircraft begins to pivot on one or the other of the main wheels. From that point, with the CG aft of that pivot point, the forward momentum of the plane acts to continue and even tighten the turn without further steering inputs. Ordinarily, removal of rudder pressure does not stop a turn that has been started, and it is necessary to apply an opposite input (opposite rudder) to bring the aircraft back to straight-line travel. For this reason, many tailwheel airplanes are equipped with a centering spring(s) or similar device that returns the tailwheel to a center position upon relaxation of a rudder pedal input. However, this mechanism may not return the airplane to a straight line of travel from a tight turn.

If the initial rudder input is maintained after a turn has been started, the turn continues to tighten, an unexpected result for pilots accustomed to a nose-wheel. In consequence, it is common for pilots making the transition between the two types to experience difficulty in early taxi attempts. As long as taxi speeds are kept low, however, no serious problems result, and pilots typically adjust quickly to the technique of using rudder pressure to start a turn, then neutralizing the pedals as the turn continues, and finally using an opposite pedal input to stop the turn and regain straight-line travel.

Because of this inbuilt instability, the most important lesson that can be taught in tailwheel airplanes is to taxi and make turns at slow speeds.

Angle of Attack

A second strong contrast to nose-wheel airplanes, tailwheel aircraft make lift while on the ground anytime there is a relative headwind. The amount of lift obviously depends on the wind speed, but even at slow taxi speeds, the wings and ailerons are doing their best to aid in liftoff. This phenomenon requires care and management, especially during the takeoff and landing rolls, and is again unexpected by nose-wheel pilots making the transition.

Taxiing

On most tailwheel-type airplanes, directional control while taxiing is facilitated by the use of a steerable tailwheel, which operates along with the rudder. The tailwheel steering mechanism remains engaged when the tailwheel is operated through an arc of about 30° each side of center. Beyond that limit, the tailwheel breaks free and becomes full swiveling. In full swivel mode, the airplane can be pivoted within its own length, if desired. While taxiing, the steerable tailwheel should be used for making normal turns and the pilot's feet kept off the brake pedals to avoid unnecessary wear on the brakes.

When beginning to taxi, the brakes should be tested immediately for proper operation. This is done by first applying power to start the airplane moving slowly forward, then retarding the throttle and simultaneously applying pressure smoothly to both brakes. If braking action is unsatisfactory, the engine should be shut down immediately.

To turn the airplane on the ground, the pilot should apply rudder in the desired direction of turn and use whatever power or brake necessary to control the taxi speed. At very low taxi speeds, directional response is sluggish as surface friction acting on the tailwheel inhibits inputs through the steering springs. At normal taxi speeds, rudder inputs alone should be sufficient to start and stop most turns. During taxi, the AOA built in to the structure gives control placement added importance when compared to nose-wheel models.

When taxiing in a quartering headwind, the upwind wing can easily be lifted by gusting or strong winds unless ailerons are positioned to "kill" lift on that side (stick held into the wind). This is standard control positioning for both nose-wheel and tailwheel airplanes, so the difference lies only in the added tailwheel vulnerability created by the fuselage pitch attitude. At the same time, elevator should usually be held full back to add downward pressure to the tailwheel assembly and improve tailwheel steering response. However, in a strong quartering headwind a wing could lift, and the elevator may be held closer to neutral.

When taxiing with a quartering tailwind, this fuselage angle reduces the tendency of the wind to lift either wing. Nevertheless, the basic vulnerability to surface winds common to all tailwheel airplanes makes it essential to be aware of wind direction at all times, so holding the stick away from the crosswind is good practice (left aileron in a right quartering tailwind).

Elevator positioning in tailwinds is a bit more complex. Standard teaching tends to recommend full forward stick in any degree of tailwind, arguing that a tailwind striking the elevator when it is deflected full down increases downward pressure on the tailwheel assembly and increases directional control. Equally important, if the elevator were to remain deflected up, a strong tailwind can get under the control surface and lift the tail with unfortunate consequences for the propeller and engine.

While stick-forward positioning is essential in strong tailwinds, it is not likely to be an appropriate response when winds are light. The propeller wash in even lightly-powered airplanes is usually strong enough to overcome the effects of light tailwinds, producing a net headwind over the tail. This in turn suggests that back stick, not forward, does the most to help with directional control. If in doubt, it is best to sample the wind as you taxi and position the elevator where it will do the most good.

Weathervaning

Tailwheel airplanes have an exaggerated tendency to weathervane, or turn into the wind, when operated on the ground in crosswinds. This tendency is greatest when taxiing with a direct crosswind, a factor that makes maintaining directional control more difficult, sometimes requiring use of the brakes when tailwheel steering alone proves inadequate to counteract the weathervane effect.

Visibility

In the normal nose-high attitude, the engine cowling may be high enough to restrict the pilot's vision of the area directly ahead of the airplane while on the ground. Consequently, objects directly ahead are difficult, if not impossible to see. In aircraft that are completely blind ahead, all taxi movements should be started with a small turn to ensure no other plane or ground vehicle has positioned itself directly under the nose while the pilot's attention was distracted with getting ready to takeoff. In taxiing such an airplane, the pilot should alternately turn the nose from one side to the other (zigzag) or make a series of short S-turns. This should be done slowly, smoothly, positively, and cautiously.

Directional Control

After absorbing all the information presented to this point, the transitioning pilot may conclude that the best approach to maintaining directional control is to limit rudder inputs from fear of overcontrolling. Although intuitive, this is an incorrect assumption: the disadvantages built in to the tailwheel design sometimes require vigorous rudder inputs to maintain or retain directional control. The best approach is to understand the fact that tailwheel aircraft are not damaged from the use of too much rudder, but rather from rudder inputs held for too long.

Normal Takeoff Roll

Wing flaps should be lowered prior to takeoff if recommended by the manufacturer. After taxiing onto the runway, the airplane should be aligned with the intended takeoff direction, and the tailwheel positioned straight or centered. In airplanes equipped with a locking device, the tailwheel should be locked in the centered position. After releasing the brakes, the throttle should be smoothly and continuously advanced to takeoff power. The pilot should carefully avoid applying brake pressure during the takeoff roll.

After a brief period of acceleration, positive forward elevator should be applied to smoothly lift the tail. The goal is to achieve a pitch attitude that improves forward visibility and produces a smooth transition to climbing flight as the aircraft continues to accelerate.

It is important to note that nose-down pitch movement produces left yaw, the result of gyroscopic precession created by the propeller. The amount of force created by this precession is directly related to the rate the propeller axis is tilted when the tail is raised, so it is best to avoid an abrupt pitch change. Whether smooth or abrupt, the need to react to this yaw with rudder inputs emphasizes the increased directional demands common to tailwheel airplanes, a demand likely to be unanticipated by pilots transitioning from nose-wheel models.

As speed is gained on the runway, the added authority of the elevator naturally continues to pitch the nose forward. During this stage, the pilot should concentrate on maintaining a constant-pitch attitude by gradually reducing elevator deflection. At the same time, directional control should be maintained with smooth, prompt, positive rudder corrections. All this activity emphasizes the point that tailwheel planes start to "fly" long before leaving the runway surface.

Liftoff

When the appropriate pitch attitude is maintained throughout the takeoff roll, liftoff occurs when the AOA and airspeed combine to produce the necessary lift without any additional "rotation" input. The ideal takeoff attitude requires only minimum pitch adjustments shortly after the airplane lifts off to attain the desired climb speed.

All modern tailwheel aircraft can be lifted off in the three-point attitude. That is, the AOA with all three wheels on the ground does not exceed the critical AOA, and the wings will not be stalled. While instructive, this technique results in an unusually high pitch attitude and an AOA excessively close to stall, both inadvisable circumstances when flying only inches from the ground.

As the airplane leaves the ground, the pilot should continue to maintain straight flight and hold the proper pitch attitude. During takeoffs in strong, gusty winds, it is advisable to add an extra margin of speed before the airplane is allowed to leave the ground. A takeoff at the normal takeoff speed may result in a lack of positive control, or a stall, when the airplane encounters a sudden lull in strong, gusty wind or other turbulent air currents. In this case, the pilot should hold the airplane on the ground longer to attain more speed, then make a smooth, positive rotation to leave the ground.

Crosswind Takeoff

It is important to establish and maintain proper crosswind corrections prior to liftoff; that is, application of aileron deflection into the wind to keep the upwind wing from rising and rudder deflection as needed to prevent weathervaning.

Takeoffs made into strong crosswinds are the reason for maintaining a positive AOA (tail-low attitude) while accelerating on the runway. Because the wings are making lift during the takeoff roll, a strong upwind aileron deflection can bank the airplane into the wind and provide positive crosswind correction soon after the takeoff roll begins. The remainder of the takeoff roll is then made on the upwind main wheel while the pilot uses rudder to maintain the alignment of the longitudinal axis with the runway. As the airplane accelerates, the pilot smoothly decreases the pitch attitude and adjusts aileron and rudder control pressures to maintain the appropriate crosswind correction. If the pitch attitude remains excessively steep or if it is too flat, crosswind control during the ground roll becomes more difficult. As the aircraft leaves the runway, the wings can be leveled as appropriate drift correction (crab) is established.

Short-Field Takeoff

With the exception of flap settings and initial climb speed as recommended by the manufacturer, there is little difference between the techniques described above for normal takeoffs. After liftoff, the pitch attitude should be adjusted as required for obstacle clearance. However, note that manufacturers of some airplanes, especially of higher power, recommend a short-field technique with liftoff in a three-point attitude. Pilots should always review and follow the airplane manufacturer's recommended procedures.

Soft-Field Takeoff

Wing flaps may be lowered prior to starting the takeoff (if recommended by the manufacturer) to provide additional lift and transfer the airplane's weight from the wheels to the wings as early as possible. The airplane should be taxied onto the takeoff surface without stopping on a soft surface since mud or snow might bog the airplane down. The airplane should be kept in continuous motion with sufficient power while lining up for the takeoff roll. Due to the high power settings, it is usually best to have the elevator full up while taxiing onto the runway in soft conditions. There is not only the danger of the airplane bogging down, but also a danger of it tipping up onto its nose.

As the airplane is aligned with the proposed takeoff path, takeoff power is applied smoothly and as rapidly as the powerplant will accept without faltering. The tail should be kept very low to maintain the inherent positive AOA and to avoid any tendency of the airplane to nose over as a result of soft spots, tall grass, or deep snow.

When the airplane is held at a nose-high attitude throughout the takeoff run, the wings progressively relieve the wheels of more and more of the airplane's weight, thereby minimizing the drag caused by surface irregularities or adhesion. Once airborne, the airplane should be allowed to accelerate to climb speed in ground effect.

Landing

The difference between nose-wheel and tailwheel airplanes becomes apparent when discussing the touchdown and the period of deceleration to taxi speed. In the nose-wheel design, touchdown is followed quite naturally by a reduction in pitch attitude to bring the nose-wheel tire into contact with the runway. This pitch change reduces AOA, removes almost all wing lift, and rapidly transfers aircraft weight to the tires.

In tailwheel designs, this reduction of AOA and weight transfer are not practical and, as noted in the section on takeoffs, it is rare to encounter tailwheel planes designed so that the wings are beyond critical AOA in the three-point attitude. In consequence, the airplane continues to "fly" in the three-point attitude after touchdown, requiring careful attention to heading, roll, and pitch for an extended period.

Touchdown

Tailwheel airplanes are less forgiving of crosswind landing errors than nose-wheel models. It is important that touchdown occurs with the airplane's longitudinal axis parallel to the direction the airplane is moving along the runway. *[Figure 14-2]* Failure to accomplish this imposes side loads on the landing gear which leads to directional instability. To avoid side stresses and directional problems, the pilot should not allow the airplane to touch down while in a crab or while drifting.

There are two significantly different techniques used to manage tailwheel aircraft touchdowns: three-point and wheel landings. In the first, the airplane is held off the surface of the runway until the attitude needed to remain aloft matches the geometry of the landing gear. When touchdown occurs at this point, the main gear and the tailwheel make contact at the same time. In the second technique (wheel landings), the airplane is allowed to touch down earlier in the process in a lower pitch attitude, so that the main gear touch while the tail remains off the runway.